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Summary

The essay begins by addressing the critical issue of undernutrition in developing countries, particularly in children. The aim is to assess the effectiveness of UNICEF's evidence-based interventions in combating undernutrition. The introduction highlights the severity of the problem, citing statistics from WHO and UNICEF. Undernutrition is defined as a lack of nutrients in the body, with detrimental effects on children's health, immune systems, and overall growth. The essay sets the stage for a detailed examination of UNICEF's intervention strategies, emphasizing the importance of evidence-based practices in improving healthcare outcomes. It also mentions the classification of undernutrition into various categories, such as underweight, stunting, wasting, and deficiencies in vitamins and minerals. The introduction concludes by underscoring the broader implications of addressing undernutrition, linking it to the general improvement of population health, well-being, and advancements in health and care systems.

Introduction

This paper aims to examine the problem of undernutrition in developing countries and assess the efficacy of UNICEF's evidence-based interventions and their impact on fighting undernutrition in children. It will additionally provide solutions to solve the crisis according to the chosen intervention. This analysis will be connected to the general improvement of population health and well-being as well as the advancement of methods for health and care systems. The chosen healthcare crisis, undernutrition, is simply defined as a lack of nutrients in the human body (WHO, 2021). According to WHO (2021), 149 million children under five years old are stunted and 45 million are wated worldwide. Therefore, undernutrition harms children, weakens their immune systems, and heightens the risk of illness, death, and delayed growth (UNICEF, 2021).

Beyond its severe health consequences, undernutrition has far-reaching consequences that affect entire communities and economies. Among others, Dr. Sania Nishtar emphasizes how it not only jeopardizes individual health but also threatens fundamental human rights and delays economic progress (Nations, 2019). Understanding the larger consequences is critical as we evaluate UNICEF's actions. These initiatives aim to address not just individual health difficulties, but also to contribute to society's well-being and economic stability.

This paper will evaluate UNICEF's evidence-based programs to combat undernutrition, especially among children in developing countries. This research attempts to evaluate the success of UNICEF's initiatives and provide solutions for this critical global health issue by evaluating the historical background, accepting limitations, and stressing larger social implications.

Body of the essay

Undernutrition in developing countries is still considered a major priority and more actions should be taken to reduce barriers and provide all the help needed. Undernutrition is a deficit of nutrients in the body (Cleveland Clinic, 2022). Undernutrition can be broadly classified into four categories: underweight, stunting, wasting, and vitamin and mineral deficiencies (WHO, 2021). Children with low weight for age are referred to as underweight, low height for age is known as stunting and low weight for height is known as wasting (WHO, 2021). Undernutrition severely damages children in developing countries, and it is crucial to manage such conditions to keep their immune systems from deteriorating and making them more susceptible to illness, mortality, and delayed growth (UNICEF, 2021). Undernutrition increases mortality and morbidity and leads to longer hospital stays and higher healthcare expenses (AHRQ, 2020).

The paper will critically analyse an intervention and evidenced-based practice from UNICEF regarding the undernutrition of children in developed countries. When conducting research or practising medicine, an evidence-based approach helps improve care quality and avoids inappropriate conduct (Cardoso et al., 2021). As Cardoso et al. (2021) explain Evidence-based practices are significant because they lower healthcare costs, enhance patient satisfaction and health outcomes, and promote high-value medical treatment.

The selected intervention will be analysed using a qualitative approach throughout this paper. A qualitative approach is used when conducting research using words, text, descriptions, and textual analysis (Smith, 2023).

Some examples of previous interventions done to fight undernutrition in children in developing countries and /or low- and middle-income countries will be presented and analysed effectively. The Nounkeu and Dharod (2021) article provided proof that data was gathered from

an extensive literature review conducted using three scientific databases: EBSCO, PubMed, and Google Scholar. In this evidence-based practice, several recognised nutrition-related behavioural and regulatory treatments were implemented in this initiative, which took a multi-sectoral approach. Behavioural interventions were used throughout this process with the goal of helping children establish individual routines and habits (Nounkeu and Dharod, 2021).

When evaluating effectiveness, growth indicators did not show any significant improvements. Additionally, the research papers chosen from this article covered a wide range of interventions, from merely educational to combining education with the distribution of nutrition-related materials (Nounkeu and Dharod, 2021).

In areas where there are persistent barriers to ensuring the safety of children, UNICEF has introduced an original intervention aimed at addressing vital concerns impacting vulnerable populations. Alarming rates of nutrition among children in areas of poverty have been found in recent studies. Their development, health, and chances for the future are seriously threatened by these situations. All the following information was researched from an e-book published by the United Nations/UNICEF in 2019, regarding children's nutrition and its importance around the world. This e-book includes interventions that have affected the way our world is changing daily.

The chosen intervention is related to the nutritional status of the mother. Women who undergo significant improvements in their living conditions, diet, and overall health prior to becoming pregnant increase the likelihood that the babies may grow up to be stunted. (Nations, 2019). To improve not just the lives of women but also those of future generations, UNICEF has therefore proposed that investing in maternal nutrition is the first step in combating undernutrition in children (Nations, 2019). Through breastfeeding, the mother's nutritional state continues to influence the child after birth (Nations, 2019). The degree to which a child's family can provide sufficient food and care, as well as the child's access to health services, clean water, and sanitary facilities, are other elements that affect the child's growth (Nations, 2019). Children may become entangled in a deadly cycle of illness and malnourishment because of frequent infections and intestinal inflammation (Nations, 2019). According to Nations (2019), both the percentage and total of stunted children under five have been falling worldwide. Between 2000 and 2018, it decreased by 25% to 149 million children. This, in general, reflects growing financial stability and better governance across many nations. However, once again according to Nations (2019), much of Africa has seen a slowdown in the

reduction of stunting despite global declines. Two UNICEF regions on the continent saw an increase in the number of affected children between 2000 and 2018 the number of children under five with stunting increased by 1.4 million in Eastern and Southern Africa and by 6.5 million in West and Central Africa, reflecting the continent's powerful population growth (Nations, 2019).

Malnutrition causes more than only illnesses and deaths. In addition, it violates the human right to a healthy life and limits economic growth by driving up medical expenses and reducing productivity (Nations, 2019). Additionally, it is mentioned by Dr. Sania Nishtar from Nations (2019), that undernutrition causes production losses because it reduces physical and mental capabilities. Furthermore, there is growing recognition and evidence that efforts to prevent malnutrition pay off and are desperately required (Nations, 2019). Countries must confront the multi-headed monster that is malnutrition, both now and in the future, for the sake of our health and economies (Nations, 2019).

Moreover, undernutrition brings even bigger problems for the future of the children. Undernutrition has several negative effects on a child's ability to succeed economically and, consequently, on their overall socioeconomic development. As stated by Nations (2019), research from several nations shows that children with poor nutrition spend less time in school, usually due to delayed brain development and a lack of preparation for school, sickness, or starting school later in life and having to repeat classes. They provided evidence to support these conclusions, stating that in sub-Saharan Africa, for instance, food shortages during a child's early years might cause them to lose up to 2.5 years of schooling (Nations, 2019). Further to this, they presented counterarguments based on research showing multiple examples of the positive correlation between enhanced nutrition and improved academic achievement in children. In the 1940s, for example, the United States government mandated that bread be fortified to combat widespread iron deficiency (Nations, 2019). This investigation revealed higher rates of school enrolment. In a similar way compared to children who had not received treatment, Tanzanian children who got rigorous iodine supplementation in the late 1980s and early 1990s attended school for up to an additional half-year (Nations, 2019). Lastly, Evidence on enrichment initiatives in China and Guatemala indicates that children's proficiency in subjects like reading and math increased (Nations, 2019).

To critically analyse this approach from UNICEF, we will look now at some strengths and limitations of their intervention. UNICEF took into consideration that “lack of proper

nutrition during the early years can have lifelong consequences" (Nations, 2019) therefore, they invested in the mother's nutrition in these low-income countries. This strength shows that by focusing on mothers, UNICEF can carry out focused education and behaviour modification initiatives. Since mothers are frequently the key carers and decision-makers in their families, increasing their understanding of nutrition can benefit the whole family. Mothers with higher levels of education are more likely to make wise decisions for their families' needs in terms of hygiene, nutrition, and medical treatment (Bimpong et al., 2020). An additional strength of UNICEF intervention is that investing money into maternal nutrition can be a wise financial move. Early childhood undernutrition prevention is frequently more effective and economical than treating the effects of malnutrition later in life (Larsen et al., 2023). Infants born with healthy moms are more likely to be healthy adults, which lowers the need for costly medical procedures (Larsen et al., 2023).

On the other hand, the effectiveness of UNICEF intervention for maternal nutrition may be impacted by sociocultural norms and behaviours. Adoption of recommended measures may face obstacles due to the effect of traditional beliefs, gender roles, and cultural expectations on eating habits and healthcare-seeking behaviour (Ansong et al, 2022). Furthermore, long-term continuation of the beneficial effects of maternal nutrition treatments can be difficult. Sustaining measures and ongoing assistance are required to guarantee that changes in maternal nutrition result in long-term health advantages for mothers and their children (Keats et al., 2021).

Finalising this analysis will provide key areas where this intervention can contribute to positive outcomes. In terms of improving children's health and development, reducing childhood undernutrition can lead to enhanced physical and cognitive development (Elmighrabi et al., 2023). Furthermore, it can help to reduce the incidence of stunting and wasting, as well as contribute to greater overall health and resistance in children.

Maternal nutrition interventions have been shown to enhance the health of pregnant women, leading to healthier pregnancies and improved delivery outcomes (Marshall et al., 2021). Similarly, adequate maternal nutrition promotes the health of both mothers and infants, enabling them to have a healthier start in life (Marshall et al., 2021).

Another positive outcome of their intervention is that improving mother and child health not only promotes the building of robust and resilient healthcare systems but also strengthens the capacity required to address undernutrition concerns within these systems through targeted nutrition programs (King et al., 2020).

There are always ethical considerations when implementing these types of interventions. It is essential that these services are available to all women, regardless of financial status, ethnic background, or geographical location. If these discrepancies are not addressed, they may increase current health inequities. Adding up to this, there are also privacy and confidentiality considerations for the individuals that should be taken into consideration. It is critical to protect the privacy and anonymity of persons who participate in maternal nutrition programs (Murray, 2023). To avoid discrimination or unexpected effects, information regarding a woman's health state, eating habits, or any other personal facts should be handled with prudence (Murray, 2023).

By addressing these ethical concerns, maternal nutrition interventions may be conducted in a way which preserves women's dignity and rights, improves community well-being, and leads to long-term gains in mother and child health.

Throughout this assignment, research was completed, and research papers were reviewed for quality. Aside from CRAAP, three databases were used for research, including WHO, UNICEF, and Google Scholar. The letters CRAAP stand for Currency, Relevance, Authority, Accuracy, and Purpose (Kurpiel, 2023). The chosen papers were subjected to each CRAAP component to find out whether they should be included in this essay. Currency was evaluated to determine the information's timeliness, relevance to the study topic, authority to determine the writers' credibility, accuracy to determine the content's dependability, and purpose to determine the publication's intended meaning (Kurpiel, 2023). During the research, several key terms were used including undernutrition in children; UNICEF; approaches to combat undernutrition; undernutrition in developing countries; evidence-based interventions; the significance of mothers' nutritional health; and children's safety.

This precise evaluation procedure guaranteed the inclusion of reliable sources, which also improved the overall validity, accuracy, and consistency of the evidence-based conclusions.

Furthermore, systematic reviews are essential resources for precisely summarizing the available data, supporting clinicians, educating policymakers, assisting patients, and acting as a basis for funding choices and clinical practice guidelines (Connor et al., 2023). Nonetheless, a significant issue that diminishes the potential worth of many systematic reviews is the incomplete reporting of important information (Connor et al., 2023). Additionally, PRISMA was created in response to the need for better systematic review reporting and conduct (Connor

et al., 2023). This will make it easier for authors to report on a variety of systematic reviews that evaluate the advantages and disadvantages of healthcare interventions (Connor et al., 2023).

Over and above that, a framework is present to assist in focusing the discussion and providing direction. PEO will serve as a framework throughout this essay to help in the development of seeking results. PEO stands for Population (P), Exposure (E) and Outcome (O) (O'Driscoll, 2023). In this case, the chosen population are the children of developing countries, the exposure is the maternal nutrition and empowerment and finally, the outcome is the reduction in the undernutrition rate, measured by indicators such as stunting, wasting, or underweight.

Conclusion

Undernutrition is a worldwide health concern with long-term consequences, which is why it is critical to research and develop solutions to eliminate it. All interventions are important, whether they be breastfeeding, washing hands before eating, having a clean surrounding, or drinking clean, safe water. There is no single technique that communities must take to achieve major changes.

Additionally, addressing limitations demands a multidimensional strategy that considers the larger social, economic, and environmental context in which maternal nutrition interventions are carried out. It is also suggested that integrating solutions with larger development goals and ensuring that programs are culturally sensitive and context-appropriate should be highlighted.

In conclusion, concentrating on mothers' nutrition is a strategic strength for UNICEF because it targets the core causes of undernutrition, promotes intergenerational health, empowers communities, and takes a holistic approach to improving the well-being of both mothers and their children.

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